

Attachment 2 – Section L & M
Network Operations & Support Center (NOSC)
Solicitation Number: SSN26-7571-IHSNOSC

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1 SECTION L – INSTRUCTIONS, CONDITIONS, AND NOTICES TO OFFERORS

L.1 GENERAL INSTRUCTIONS

This solicitation is issued in accordance with FAR Part 15. Offerors shall prepare proposals in accordance with the instructions contained herein.

- The Government will evaluate proposals based solely on the information provided in the Offeror's proposal. The Government will not assume the existence of any capability, understanding, or commitment not clearly and explicitly described in the Offeror's proposal.
- Proposals shall be specific, detailed, and complete, demonstrating a clear understanding of the PWS requirements and the Offeror's capability to provide the required outcomes.
- Generic, boilerplate, or restated PWS language without substantive detail may be evaluated as a lack of understanding and may result in a lower evaluation rating.

Failure to follow the instructions in this section may result in the proposal being determined unacceptable or may adversely affect the evaluation

L.2 PROPOSAL ORGANIZATION

The Offeror shall submit proposals in the following volumes:

- Volume I – Technical Approach
- Volume II – Key Personnel and Management Approach
- Volume III – Past Performance
- Volume IV – Price

Each volume shall be separately organized and self-contained. The proposal should be formatted to clearly identify how each requirement is addressed. Offerors shall cross-reference responses to the applicable PWS sections and evaluation factors.

L.2.1 PAGE LIMITATIONS

To ensure efficient evaluation, the following page limits apply:

- Volume I – Technical Approach: 20 pages
- Volume II – Management Approach: 15 pages (excluding resumes)
- Volume III – Past Performance: 10 pages

Pages exceeding these limits may not be evaluated.

L.2.2 SUBMISSION INSTRUCTIONS

Proposals shall be submitted electronically via (TBD).
Late submissions may not be considered.

L.3 VOLUME I – TECHNICAL APPROACH

The contract technical requirements are to support a large-scale, mission-critical enterprise network environment that includes:

- Approximately 400 sites, including remote and rural locations with constrained telecommunications service, supporting more than 20,000 connected users
- Telecommunications services are delivered through multiple providers, utilizing MPLS, internet, satellite, and 5G wireless transport options to provide cost effective connectivity for sites located in urban and rural locations.
- A transport-agnostic Wide Area Network architecture leveraging Cisco SD-WAN technology to enable dynamic path selection, segmentation, and resilient connectivity across multiple transport types
- Integrated on-premises and cloud-based network security capabilities, providing network perimeter protection, threat inspection, and policy enforcement, fully integrated with the SD-WAN architecture
- Multi-vendor cloud connectivity, interconnected with on-premises data center networks to support secure, high-performance seamless integration between cloud and on-premises hosted IT applications
- Enterprise network operations and monitoring services delivering continuous 24x7x365 visibility, proactive issue detection, incident response, and coordinated service desk support to maintain network availability and performance
- Enterprise security compliance services ensuring continuous adherence to Federal cybersecurity requirements, including FISMA and NIST standards, through implementation, monitoring, and validation of required security controls
- Automation and AIOps capabilities leveraging data correlation, predictive analytics, and orchestration to improve operational efficiency, reduce manual effort, and enable proactive identification and resolution of network issues

Offerors shall demonstrate a proven, technically credible approach, supported by direct, hands-on experience of its proposed personnel, in operating and managing environments comparable to the IHS network. The Government will evaluate the extent to which the proposal reflects operational experience in enterprise-scale environments, rather than theoretical knowledge or generalized IT service capability.

NOTE: The repeated use of the highlighted phase in the elements below is to emphasize the need for Offerors to have hands-on, enterprise-scale experience - to help weed out weak Offerors that respond with generic IT experience rather than proven capability in comparable environments. Delete this note and unhighlight.

L.3.1 ELEMENT 1 – NETWORK ARCHITECTURE, DESIGN, AND OPERATIONS

Offerors shall describe a proven, technically credible approach, supported by direct, hands-on experience of its proposed personnel, in architecting, designing, and operating large-scale enterprise network environments comparable to the IHS network. The response should include:

- Experience of the proposed team to architect, design and operate a geographically dispersed networks consisting of hundreds of interconnected sites with 20,000 plus users
- Experience managing complex routing architectures, including dynamic routing protocols, traffic engineering, and failover across distributed environments
- Experience operating software-defined networking environments, including Cisco SD-WAN, with centralized policy management
- Experience integrating LAN, WAN, wireless, and data center environments into a unified enterprise architecture
- Ability to maintain high availability, with redundancy design, failover mechanisms, and performance optimization
- Approach to how network architecture failures (e.g., routing instability, SD-WAN misconfiguration, or transport outages) will be identified, mitigated, and resolved in a manner that maintains continuity of mission-critical service

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates actual operational experience designing and managing enterprise-scale network architectures, rather than theoretical knowledge or generalized networking capability.

L.3.2 ELEMENT 2 – TELECOMMUNICATIONS SERVICES MANAGEMENT

Offerors shall describe a proven, technically credible approach, supported by direct, hands-on experience of its proposed personnel, in managing enterprise telecommunications services delivered through multiple providers within environments comparable to the IHS network.

- Experience managing large-scale WAN environments with diverse service connectivity (e.g., MPLS, internet, SD-WAN, wireless, satellite)

- Experience coordinating with multiple telecommunications providers for provisioning, escalation, and performance management
- Experience ensuring high network availability and performance across distributed locations

The Offeror shall describe how simultaneous or cascading telecommunications failures (e.g., multi-provider outages, degraded circuits, or regional disruptions) will be identified, managed, and resolved to minimize service disruption.

L.3.3 ELEMENT 3 – NETWORK SECURITY DESIGN AND SUPPORT

Offerors shall describe a proven, technically credible approach, supported by direct, hands-on experience of its proposed personnel, in designing, implementing, and operating enterprise-scale network security architectures comparable to the IHS environment. The response shall demonstrate:

- Experience managing large firewall deployments
- Experience with Palo Alto firewall platforms, including centralized management platforms (Panorama, Strata Cloud Manager)
- Experience implementing and operating Prisma Access (SASE) or comparable secure access architectures
- Experience integrating Cisco SD-WAN with Prisma Access security controls
- Proven ability to manage:
 - Security policy enforcement
 - Advanced threat detection
 - Traffic decryption and data loss prevention

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates actual operational experience managing enterprise-scale network security environments, including large firewall deployments and integrated SASE architectures.

L.3.4 ELEMENT 4 – CLOUD AND HYBRID NETWORK INTEGRATION

Offerors shall describe a proven, technically credible approach, supported by direct, hands-on experience of its proposed personnel, in designing, implementing, and operating multi-vendor cloud connectivity integrated with on-premises data center networks within enterprise environments comparable to the IHS network. The response shall demonstrate:

- Experience implementing and support cloud provider Infrastructure as a Service (IaaS) network capabilities

- Experience designing and implementing secure connectivity to cloud environments through different transport capabilities.
- Experience ensuring secure and reliable connectivity between cloud-hosted and on-premises IT services

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates actual operational experience managing hybrid cloud environments of similar scale and complexity, not theoretical knowledge or generalized cloud capabilities.

L.3.5 ELEMENT 5 – NETWORK MONITORING AND AUTOMATION

Offerors shall describe a proven, technically credible approach, supported by direct, hands-on experience of its proposed personnel, in delivering enterprise-scale network monitoring and operations integrated with automation and AIOps capabilities.

- Experience implementing enterprise-scale monitoring solutions capable of correlating data across multiple platforms (network devices, security tools, cloud services)
- Proven ability to perform event correlation, anomaly detection, and root cause analysis across large environments
- Use of automation and AIOps to:
 - Reduce manual intervention
 - Execute repetitive operational tasks
 - Improve response times
 - Maintain configuration consistency
- Experience and approach to integrate monitoring and automation tools into daily operational workflows

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates actual operational experience implementing and using monitoring and automation capabilities in enterprise-scale environments, rather than conceptual or tool-based descriptions.

L.3.6 Element 6 – Integrated Service Delivery and IT Service Management

Offerors shall describe a proven, technically credible approach, supported by direct, hands-on experience of its proposed personnel, in delivering services through a fully integrated operational model utilizing IT Service Management (ITSM) processes in enterprise environments comparable to the IHS network. The response shall demonstrate:

- Approach to provide quality 24x7x365 support coverage, consistent service delivery, and enhance operational maturity through continuous improvement applicable to the IHS network system environment
- Ability to coordinate support services across all functional areas (network, security, telecom, cloud) and technologies (routing, switching, firewalls, and wireless)
- Approach to multi-domain incidents will be coordinated, managed, and resolved which may require collaboration with multiple IT service owners

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates actual operational experience delivering integrated service management across multiple network service and technology domains, rather than conceptual descriptions of ITIL processes.

L.3.7 ELEMENT 7 – PHASE-IN / PHASE-OUT PLAN

Offeror shall describe a proven, executable transition approach, supported by direct, hands-on experience of its proposed personnel, in assuming and relinquishing responsibility for enterprise-scale network operations comparable to the IHS environment. The response shall demonstrate:

- Experience transitioning complex IT operations contracts
- Detailed approach to:
 - Knowledge transfer
 - Staff onboarding
 - Risk mitigation
- Ability to achieve full operational capability within 30 days
- Approach to maintaining continuity of operations during transition

The Offeror shall describe how it will respond to transition failures or unexpected conditions (e.g., incomplete documentation, delayed access, or personnel availability issues) while maintaining uninterrupted mission-critical operations.

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates actual experience executing successful transitions in enterprise-scale environments, rather than conceptual or generic transition plans

L.3.8 Element 8 – Section 508 Compliance

In accordance with HHSAR 352.239-73(b), Electronic and Information Technology Accessibility Notice (DEC 2015), Offerors shall demonstrate their approach to ensuring compliance with Section 508 accessibility requirements for all Electronic and Information

Technology (EIT) products and services provided under this contract. The response shall demonstrate:

- A clear understanding of Section 508 requirements and applicable accessibility standards for the services provided through this contract
- Experience implementing, testing and maintaining accessibility compliance for services provided through this contract
- Methods for testing and validating compliance for services provided through this contract

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates a credible, actionable, and repeatable approach to ensuring Section 508 compliance.

L.4 VOLUME II – KEY PERSONNEL AND MANAGEMENT APPROACH

Offerors shall demonstrate a proven, realistic, and executable management approach, supported by qualified personnel with direct, hands-on experience, to operate a large-scale, 24x7x365 enterprise network environment comparable to the IHS network and provide contract deliverables.

L.4.1 ELEMENT 1 – KEY PERSONNEL

Offeror shall identify four (4) to seven (7) Key Personnel responsible for leading major functional areas in the PWS. For each Key Personnel, Offerors shall:

- Identify the proposed role and responsibilities
- Identify the specific PWS section(s) the individual shall lead
- Submit a resume (maximum three (3) pages per individual)
- Provide a detailed narrative describing how the individual's skills, experience and certifications are directly applicable to the specific PWS requirements.

Letters of Commitment

Each Key Personnel shall provide a signed Letter of Commitment confirming:

- Availability at contract start
- Commitment to the proposed role
- No conflicting obligations

Personnel Availability and Exclusivity

Personnel shall be fully dedicated to this contract and shall not simultaneously support other customers, including assignments on other IHS contracts. If proposed personnel are currently assigned to another IHS contract, the Offeror shall:

- Identify the assignment
- Provide a transition plan
- Demonstrate availability

L.4.2 ELEMENT 2 – STAFFING MODEL AND ORGANIZATIONAL STRUCTURE

Offerors shall demonstrate a fully developed, realistic staffing model capable of supporting all PWS requirements. Offerors shall provide:

- Organizational/staffing chart showing supervision and reporting structure
- Description of roles and responsibilities
- A 24x7x365 operational coverage plan
- A complete staff listing, including labor categories, number of personnel and assigned annual hours.

The Offeror shall map staffing to specific PWS sections and functional areas

The Government will evaluate whether the staffing model:

- Reflects the complexity and scale of the IHS network
- Supports simultaneous operations across multiple sites
- Enables continuous 24x7x365 operations

Understaffed or unrealistic models will be evaluated as high risk.

Non-Key Personnel

The Offeror shall provide baseline qualification standards for each labor category, including skills, experience and certifications

L.4.3 ELEMENT 3 - TEAMING ARRANGEMENTS AND PRIOR EXPERIENCE

If the Offeror proposes a Prime Contractor and subcontractor(s) to perform the NOSC requirements, the Offeror shall clearly describe the teaming staff structure and integration approach. The Offeror shall provide:

- Identification of all proposed subcontractors and their roles
- Description of how work will be divided and managed across the team
- Approach to communication, coordination, and integration among team members

In addition, the Offeror shall describe any prior experience working together as a team, including:

- Contracts or task orders where the proposed team members performed together
- Scope and complexity of the work performed
- Roles and responsibilities of each team member
- Duration of the teaming relationship
- Outcomes and performance results

If the proposed team has not previously worked together, the Offeror shall:

- Clearly state this
- Describe how it will mitigate the risks associated with a newly formed team, including:
 - Integration of personnel and processes
 - Communication and coordination mechanisms
 - Transition and startup approach

L.4.4 ELEMENT 4 – STAFF RETENTION, STABILITY, AND TRAINING

Offerors shall demonstrate a proven workforce management approach and describe their plan for staff retention and training during the life of the contract.

- **Retention Strategy**
 - Methods for retaining qualified personnel
 - Minimizing turnover
- **Workforce Stability**
 - Maintaining continuity of operations
 - Preventing loss of institutional knowledge
- **Recruitment Capability**
 - Ability to recruit specialized technical staff
- **Training and Development**

- Ongoing technical training
- Maintaining workforce skillsets over contract lifecycle
- **Workforce Risk**
 - The Offeror shall demonstrate how risks will be mitigated for:
 - Personnel turnover
 - Skill gaps

L.5 VOLUME III – PAST PERFORMANCE

Offerors shall submit recent and relevant past performance information demonstrating ability to successfully perform requirements similar in size, scope, and complexity to the NOSC requirement.

The Offeror may include past performance information for work performed as a subcontractor if their role was significant to overall contract performance. Offerors shall clearly describe their role and contribution to the NOSC contract.

Offerors without relevant past performance shall indicate “No Relevant Past Performance” in their submission. A neutral rating will be assigned in accordance with FAR.

L.5.1 SUBMISSION REQUIREMENTS

The Offeror shall submit information for up to three (3) contracts or task orders performed within the last five (5) years from the date of solicitation issuance. Each reference shall include:

- Contract number
- Customer/Agency name
- Contracting Officer or Contracting Officer’s Representative (name, phone, email)
- Period of performance
- Contract type (e.g., FFP, T&M)
- Total contract value
- Description of services performed

Offerors should clearly indicate whether they were the prime or subcontractor on the contract.

L.5.2 ELEMENT 1 - RELEVANCE AND NARRATIVE DESCRIPTION

For each reference, Offerors shall provide a clear narrative describing the relevance of the work performed to the NOSC requirement. Offerors shall explicitly demonstrate how each reference is comparable in size, scope, and complexity, including:

- Operation of enterprise network environments, including:
 - Large, geographically distributed networks
 - High user populations
 - 24x7x365 operations
- Experience managing:
 - Network operations and monitoring
 - Network security and compliance
 - Telecommunications services across multiple providers
 - Hybrid cloud and on-premises environments
- Experience supporting Federal or similarly regulated environments (e.g., FISMA, NIST)

The narrative shall include:

- Scope and complexity of the effort
- Number of sites and users supported
- Technologies used (e.g., SD-WAN, Palo Alto, cloud connectivity)
- Operational requirements (e.g., high availability, continuous operations)

Offerors shall clearly explain how and why each reference is relevant to the NOSC requirement.

L.5.3 ELEMENT 2 - GOVERNMENT DATA SOURCES

The Federal Government uses the Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System (CPARS) to document Contractor performance information which is required by the Federal Acquisition Regulations. Past performance information entered to CPARS is available to Federal agencies through a separate system called the Past Performance Information Retrieval System (PPIRS) for source selection purposes.

L.6 VOLUME IV – PRICE

Offerors shall provide a complete price proposal in accordance with the pricing template provided in Section B.

The information submitted should include pricing for the base period CLINs and Optional Period CLINs. The price breakdown should include the names, labor categories, hourly rates, hours and total price for each individual.

Not-to-exceed travel costs of \$10,000 for the base and option periods will be added to the total award amount.

2 SECTION M – EVALUATION FACTORS FOR AWARD

M.1 BASIS FOR AWARD

The Government will award a contract resulting from this solicitation to the Offeror whose proposal represents the best value to the Government, considering the evaluation factors set forth below. The Government intends to evaluate proposals and make an award without discussion; however, the Government reserves the right to conduct discussions if determined necessary.

M.2 EVALUATION FACTORS

Proposals will be evaluated using the following factors:

- Factor 1 – Technical Approach
- Factor 2 – Key Personnel and Management Approach
- Factor 3 – Past Performance
- Factor 4 – Price

M.3 Relative Importance of Factors

The evaluation factors are listed in descending order of importance:

- Technical Approach
- Key Personnel and Management Approach
- Past Performance

When combined, all non-price factors are significantly more important than Price.

As proposals become more equal in non-price factors, Price will become more important in the award decision.

M.4 FACTOR 1 – TECHNICAL APPROACH

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates a specific, technically credible, and executable approach to performing the PWS within the IHS enterprise network environment.

M.4.1 NETWORK ARCHITECTURE, DESIGN, AND OPERATIONS

Evaluation will consider:

- Experience operating large-scale, geographically distributed networks
- Ability to design and manage complex routing architectures
- Experience with Cisco SD-WAN or equivalent technologies
- Ability to maintain high availability, resiliency, and performance

Proposals reflecting only small-scale or theoretical experience may be evaluated as increased risk.

M.4.2 NETWORK MONITORING, OPERATIONS, AND AUTOMATION

Evaluation will consider:

- Ability to provide 24x7x365 situational awareness
- Experience with data correlation across network, security, and cloud systems
- Use of automation and AIOps to improve operational efficiency
- Ability to detect and resolve complex, multi-domain incidents

Generic statements without demonstrated operational capability may be evaluated as insufficient.

M.4.3 TELECOMMUNICATIONS SERVICES MANAGEMENT

Evaluation will consider:

- Experience managing multi-provider telecommunications environments
- Experience with MPLS, internet, satellite, and 5G wireless transport
- Ability to support remote and rural connectivity constraints
- Ability to integrate telecommunications with enterprise network operations

Limited or single-provider experience managing a small number of telecommunication services may be evaluated as increased risk.

M.4.4 NETWORK SECURITY DESIGN AND SUPPORT

Evaluation will consider:

- Experience managing complex on-premises and cloud-based firewall deployments
- Experience with Palo Alto platforms and Prisma Access (SASE)
- Experience Integrating network security with SD-WAN and cloud environments
- Ability to detect, prevent, and respond to threats
- Experience implementing NIST SP 800-53 security controls for continuous Authority to Operate compliance

Failure to demonstrate experience with comparable technologies and scale may be evaluated as high performance risk.

M.4.5 CLOUD AND HYBRID NETWORK INTEGRATION

Evaluation will consider:

- Experience supporting multi-vendor cloud environments
- Integration of cloud and on-premises networks
- Secure connectivity and performance across hybrid environments
- Integration with SD-WAN and security architecture

Lack of demonstrated operational experience may be evaluated as increased risk.

M.4.6 Integrated Service Delivery and ITSM

Evaluation will consider:

- Ability to deliver a fully integrated operational model to meet NOSC requirements
- Coordination across network, security, telecom, and cloud domains
- Implementation of ITSM processes in real operational environments
- Ability to ensure consistent and coordinated service delivery

Siloed or fragmented approaches may be evaluated as increased risk.

M.4.7 Phase-In / Phase-Out Plan

Evaluation will consider:

- Ability to achieve full operational capability within 30 days
- Experience transitioning enterprise-scale contracts
- Risk identification and mitigation strategies
- Ability to maintain continuous operations during transition

Unrealistic or generic transition approaches may be evaluated as increased risk.

M.4.8 Section 508 Compliance

Evaluation will consider:

- Understanding of Section 508 requirements applicable to the NOSC requirement
- Applicable methods for testing and validating compliance
- Integration of accessibility into NOSC operations

M.5 KEY PERSONNEL AND MANAGEMENT APPROACH

The Government will evaluate the Offeror's ability to provide qualified personnel and a realistic management approach to successfully perform the PWS.

M.5.1 KEY PERSONNEL

Evaluation will consider:

- Relevance of experience to enterprise-scale environments
- Experience supporting:
 - Large networks
 - 24x7 operations
 - Distributed environments
- Experience with required technologies:
 - Cisco SD-WAN
 - Palo Alto platforms
 - SASE network architecture

- Alignment between:
 - Proposed role
 - Individual experience
- Letters of Commitment
- Personnel availability and risk of overcommitment

Personnel with experience limited to small-scale environments may be evaluated as increased risk.

M.5.2 STAFFING MODEL AND ORGANIZATIONAL STRUCTURE

Evaluation will consider:

- Adequacy and realism of staffing levels
- Alignment of staffing to PWS requirements
- Ability to support 24x7x365 operations
- Labor mix and skill alignment
- Organizational structure and reporting relationships

Understaffed or unrealistic models may be evaluated as high risk.

M.5.3 TEAMING EXPERIENCE AND INTEGRATION

The Government will evaluate the extent to which the Offeror demonstrates an effective and integrated team structure, including the ability of the Prime Contractor and subcontractors to perform as a cohesive unit. Evaluation will consider:

- The degree to which proposed team members have previously worked together on efforts of similar scope and complexity
- Demonstrated success of prior teaming arrangements
- Clarity of roles, responsibilities, and coordination across the team
- Effectiveness of the proposed approach to integrating multiple organizations into a unified operational model

For teams that have not previously worked together, the Government will evaluate:

- The Offeror's ability to identify and mitigate risks associated with a newly formed team
- The realism and effectiveness of proposed integration, communication, and coordination processes

Proposals that rely heavily on subcontractors without demonstrating proven team integration or credible integration planning may be evaluated as presenting increased performance risk.

M.5.4 STAFF RETENTION, STABILITY, AND TRAINING

Evaluation will consider:

- Effectiveness of retention strategy
- Workforce stability and continuity
- Ability to recruit qualified personnel
- Training and professional development approach

Weak workforce strategies may be evaluated as increased risk.

M.6 PAST PERFORMANCE

The Government will evaluate past performance to assess the probability of successful performance. Evaluation will consider:

- Relevance (scope, size, complexity)
- Performance quality
- Experience with enterprise network operations

Offerors without relevant past performance will be assigned a Neutral rating.

M.7 PRICE

The Government will evaluate price for:

- Completeness
- Reasonableness (FAR 15.404-1)

- Consistency with the technical proposal

The Government will use the Total Evaluated Price (Base Period plus all Option Periods) when conducting its Best Value Trade-off analysis.

M.8 INTEGRATED ASSESSMENT AND BEST VALUE TRADEOFF

The Government will perform an integrated assessment of all evaluation factors.

Award will be made to the Offeror whose proposal represents the best value to the

Government, considering both price and non-price factors.

The Government may select a higher-priced proposal if it is determined that the additional technical capability, personnel qualifications, and reduced performance risk justify the additional cost.